

Christian Nationalism: An 8-Week Study

Small groups, adult Sunday school, and individuals. 5 sessions (run as 5, 8, or 4 weeks).

This study is for small groups, adult Sunday school classes, and individuals who are tired of a phrase that has been thrown like a rock in two directions and want to know what it actually names. It walks slowly through five essays by James Bell, defining Christian nationalism without slandering the man whose grandfather landed at Normandy, and confronting the fusion of nation and faith without sneering at ordinary patriotic believers. It is built to be run by a busy volunteer with zero preparation. Every question carries the answer behind it, every silence has a backup, and every session ends in prayer rather than argument.

This is not a study that flatters one party and indicts the other. It catches the right and the left both. It asks the conservative whether he has married his country to God and refused to let anyone file for divorce, and it asks the progressive whether he fears religion in public only when it is the wrong religion. Most of all it implicates the leader and the writer. Bell does not stand outside this. He came up out of atheism into a faith already fused with the flag, he still has flags on his own platform he has not moved, and he writes from inside the indictment. So will you.

SESSION 1

What It Is and What It Is Not

AIM

To define Christian nationalism precisely as the fusion of nation and faith into one loyalty that cannot be questioned, distinct from ordinary patriotism.

TIMING

Open 5 min Discuss 35 min Close 10 min

KEY SCRIPTURE

John 18:36. Jesus tells Pilate his kingdom is not of this world, which should have ended Christian nationalism before it was born.

DISCUSSION

1. When you first heard the phrase Christian nationalism, what did you assume it meant, and where did that assumption come from?

Behind it: Surface the two distortions in the room before defining anything. Some will hear a slur against patriots, some a catchall for the other side. The point is not to settle it yet but to show that everyone arrived with a loaded definition. Land it on humility, not consensus.

2. Bell says patriotism loves a country and nationalism worships it, and the test is what happens when your country and your Christ command different things. Can you name a real moment that test would expose?

Behind it: Push past the abstract. You want a concrete fork, an actual conflict between a national loyalty and an obedience to Christ. If they cannot name one, that itself is the finding, because the nationalist has arranged his theology so the conflict can never arise.

3. The phrase one nation under God entered the Pledge in 1954 and in God we trust became the motto in 1956. What does it do to the idea of an ancient covenant to learn its dates?

Behind it: The aim is to loosen the assumption of an eternal Christian founding without mocking it. A covenant you can date to an act of Congress is a national mood that learned to talk like one. Let them sit in the discomfort rather than rescuing them from it.

4. Whitehead and Perry found the strongest Christian nationalism often among people who do not attend church much. Why should that stop a believer cold?

Behind it: This is the hinge. It means the thing is less a deep faith than an identity, a way of marking the boundary of the nation with religious language. It can flourish in a heart with very little of Christ in it. Listen for the recognition that this is not really about Jesus.

5. Bell says he is not standing outside this but writing toward himself, that he has wanted his country to be the kingdom. Where do you feel that pull in yourself?

Behind it: Move the table from diagnosis to self-implication. You are not hunting for confession to shame anyone. You want each person, including you the leader, inside the indictment, because you cannot repent of a thing you are still calling virtue.

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

What is one thing you love about your country that you would never want to lose?

ANTICIPATED OBJECTIONS

'This whole study is just a way for the left to sneer at conservative Christians who love their country and their flag.'

Sit with the half that is true before you answer. Carelessly throwing the phrase at faithful people who feed the hungry and bury the poor is its own sin, and Bell says he will not defend it. Then make the distinction gently. The study is not against loving your country. It is against the fusion that cannot repent. You can honor the grandfather at Normandy and still ask whether his grandson crossed a line he never saw.

'Warnings about religion in public are selective. People only fear faith in the public square when it is the wrong faith, and a faith driven out of public life is just another establishment wearing the mask of neutrality.'

Grant it fully, because Newbiggin saw exactly this. There is no neutral public square. The question is never whether faith shapes public life but which faith and how. Affirm the person, then point out that this is a critique of false neutrality, not a defense of fusion. The answer to a hidden establishment is not to enthrone our own. It is honest, humble public faith that can still be corrected.

CLOSING PRAYER

Father, we have loved our country, and that love is not the sin. The sin is when we let it grow too large to be corrected. Show us the line at our feet that we keep stepping over without noticing. Keep the cross above the flag in us this week, and give us the humility to be told the truth about what we have made ultimate. In the name of the King whose kingdom is not of this world, amen.

SESSION 2

Loving Versus Worshiping Your Country

AIM

To draw the line between love, which can be corrected, and worship, which cannot, and to test which one we give our country.

TIMING

Open 5 min Discuss 35 min Close 10 min

KEY SCRIPTURE

1 Samuel 8:7. When Israel demands a king to be like the nations, God says they have rejected him from being king, naming the desire as a transfer of trust.

DISCUSSION

1. Bell says the same hand goes over the heart in front of the flag and in prayer. What do you make of the two gestures being identical?

Behind it: Let the image do the work. You are not trying to prove the gesture is idolatry. You are helping them feel the rhyme a child hears and an adult has tuned out, so the rest of the session has somewhere to land.

2. The test, Bell says, is not how you feel at the parade but what you do when your country is wrong. Walk through it. What does the lover do, and what does the worshiper do?

Behind it: You want the contrast crisp. The lover says my country and grieves and resists. The worshiper says my country and defends it, because the alternative is that his god has failed. Listen for anyone who realizes they cannot remember the last time they let their country be wrong.

3. Augustine says sin is disordered love, the lesser good loved above the greater. Where, honestly, does love of country sit in your own order of loves?

Behind it: This is the heart of the session. The drunk does not love wine too much in a simple sense. He loves it out of order. Help people see the question is not how much they love their country but where that love sits relative to the kingdom, the stranger, and Christ.

4. In 1 Samuel, wanting a king to be like the nations was a transfer of trust away from the God they could not see. Where do you see that same trade today, and does it run left or right?

Behind it: Keep it even-handed here on purpose. The desire to be like the nations shows up in a conservative longing for a strong Christian country and in a progressive trust in the state to deliver salvation. Both are the same trade. Do not let the room make it a one-party sin.

5. Bell confesses he has grown hot at an insult to the flag and cool at an insult to the cross, and that the temperature gauge does not lie. What is your gauge telling you?

Behind it: Close the diagnostic loop with self-implication. The thing you defend most fiercely is the thing you actually worship, whatever your mouth confesses on Sunday. Go first as the leader if the room is slow.

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

When was the last time you felt your throat tighten with love for a place or a people?

ANTICIPATED OBJECTIONS

'Every warning against nationalism cuts one direction. Nobody scolds the rootless cosmopolitan who feels nothing for any place. The suspicion of patriotism is really just contempt for ordinary people and their loyalties.'

Bell agrees the contempt is real and common. A man who loves nowhere is not holier than a man who loves somewhere, and rootlessness is not a virtue. Affirm that fully. Then clarify the target. This is not an argument for the cold heart. It is an argument for the difference between a warm heart and an enthroned one. We are not asking anyone to love their country less. We are asking where the love sits.

'You say wanting your country to be great is really rejecting God as king. That just baptizes passivity and lets injustice run because Christians are too holy to want anything for their nation.'

This is the progressive-leaning version, and it deserves the same care. Wanting good for your country is not the sin. Israel was told to seek the welfare of Babylon. The trade God named was trust, not action, the moving of ultimate hope from the God they could not see to the strength they could point to. You can labor hard for justice in your country and still refuse to make the country your god. The two are not in tension.

CLOSING PRAYER

Lord, you alone sit at the top where no standard reaches you, and we keep trying to put other things there. We have loved good gifts out of order. We have defended what we should have grieved. Reorder our loves. Let us love our country with a love that can still tell it the truth, and let our worship belong to you alone, who were killed by an empire and rose anyway. Amen.

SESSION 3

Flags in the Sanctuary

AIM

To examine how sacred space teaches, and why a national symbol placed beside the Word fuses two faiths whether or not anyone chose it.

TIMING

Open 5 min Discuss 35 min Close 10 min

KEY SCRIPTURE

1 Kings 8:11. The glory of the Lord fills the temple so the priests cannot stand, showing the sanctuary as jealous space that tolerates no rival glory.

DISCUSSION

1. Bell notes we will fight to keep an arrangement we never chose to install. Why does a thing we never decided have more power over us than the things we did?

Behind it: Open on the asymmetry, not on flags specifically. The point is that inherited arrangements shape us beneath the level of choice. Help them see the flag is an example of a larger pattern in their own lives before it becomes a fight about cloth.

2. Bell asks where the flag stands, not whether it exists. Lobby or platform. Why does the geography change the meaning?

Behind it: Keep them on placement, not presence. A symbol beside the cross will eventually be read as the cross's equal. The eye learns from arrangement faster than the ear learns from speech. You are after the recognition that location preaches.

3. Bellah said civil religion is a real religion with its own sacred objects and holy days. If that is true, what happens when a sacred object from one faith enters the holy space of another?

Behind it: You want the word fusion. The worshiper stops feeling the seam between the two faiths and experiences patriotism and Christianity as one undivided devotion, which is the precise definition of the thing. Tie it back to session one.

4. Bell says removing a flag can be a sneer as easily as keeping it can be idolatry, that a bare platform can serve pride. How do you tell the difference?

Behind it: This protects the even-handedness. The object is not the disease. The disease is in what the object is permitted to mean. Do not let the group conclude that stripping the platform automatically makes them holy. Pride wears both arrangements.

5. Bell admits the flags on his own platform have outlasted his objections, that he is the priest who has grown used to the second altar, not the prophet clearing the temple. Where are you the priest who has grown used to something?

Behind it: Self-implication again. The honest confession is that most of us let symbols stand because keeping them is easier than explaining them. Invite people to name their own unexamined second altar, not necessarily a flag.

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

Think of the room where you first learned to worship. What stood at the front, and what did the arrangement teach you?

ANTICIPATED OBJECTIONS

'Taking the flag off the platform is just the church being ashamed of its country and siding with the cultured people who look down on patriotic believers.'

Bell says this is sometimes exactly what removal means and exactly how it is meant, and he has seen it done as a sneer. Grant that honestly. The question is not settled by moving the cloth, because pride can strip a platform as easily as idolatry can drape one. The real work is on what the symbol is allowed to mean, not on scoring the country. Lead with honoring the dead and the freedom to gather, then ask the harder question about jealous space.

'This is overthinking a piece of fabric. It is decoration. Reading idolatry into a flag stand is exactly the kind of elite suspicion that alienates ordinary people in the pew.'

Take the worry seriously, because contempt for ordinary believers is real. But Bell's point is not that the cloth is magic. It is that arrangement teaches beneath words, and a child raised beside two equal symbols absorbs the equality before he can name it. Bell says his own children have. This is not elite suspicion. It is a working pastor watching what his sanctuary teaches his sons whether he means it to or not.

CLOSING PRAYER

God of glory, you filled the temple until the priests could not stand, and you share your holy place with no rival. We have grown used to second altars and called them only cloth. Give us eyes to read the rooms we worship in. Where we have let a lesser glory stand beside the cross, give us the courage to pay the cost of moving it, and the honesty to admit when we have not. Amen.

SESSION 4

Whose Kingdom? Jesus and Political Power

AIM

To settle from the wilderness, Pilate's hall, and the cross that the kingdom of God does not advance by seizing the means the world uses to win.

TIMING

Open 5 min Discuss 35 min Close 10 min

KEY SCRIPTURE

Matthew 4:8-10. The tempter offers Jesus every kingdom for one act of worship, and his refusal is the founding decision against advancing the kingdom by the world's means.

DISCUSSION

1. In the wilderness the kingdoms were really on the table, and the price was one act of misdirected worship. Why does it matter that the offer was real and not hollow?

Behind it: If the temptation was fake, it teaches nothing. Bell insists the kingdoms were available. The point is that real power is genuinely on offer to the church, and the modest-seeming price is always a redirected worship that says power saves. Set this up as the pattern the whole session returns to.

2. Bell says the difference between Wilberforce and Christian nationalism is the difference between salt and a coup. How do you tell faithful engagement from trying to seize the throne?

Behind it: This is the crucial distinction that keeps the study from sounding like withdrawal. Wilberforce pressed a particular evil with the tools at hand and trusted a Lord who reigns whether or not the vote goes his way. He did not try to make Britain the kingdom of God. Listen for the line between pressing a cause and installing a kingdom.

3. To Pilate, Jesus offered the absence of fighting as proof his kingdom is not of this world. What does that do to the idea that the kingdom advances by winning?

Behind it: A kingdom that fights to install its king is a kingdom of this world by definition. The kingdom of God is recognizable by its refusal to take up the sword every earthly kingdom requires. Help them feel how disqualifying that is for any conquest theology.

4. The Palm Sunday crowd wanted a king to throw out Rome by force, and by week's end they wanted his blood because he would not be that king. Where do we still want the king who conquers instead of the one who dies?

Behind it: Keep this even-handed. The hunger for a king who conquers shows up on the right as a Christian strongman and on the left as a politics that will finally force the world right. Both want power that conquers rather than power that dies. Do not let the room aim it at one side.

5. Bell confesses the gauge of his hope on election night has told the truth about which kingdom he was serving. What did your last election night reveal about where your hope actually went?

Behind it: The wilderness temptation in a voting booth offers the kingdoms for one act of misdirected worship, the worship that says power saves. You are after honesty about where hope traveled when the returns came in, not which way anyone voted. Go first if needed.

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

If you could change one thing about the world by simply winning an election, what would it be, and would winning actually fix it?

ANTICIPATED OBJECTIONS

'A kingdom not of this world is just an excuse to retreat from politics and leave the vulnerable to whoever does not retreat. The prophets confronted kings. We should too.'

Bell grants this almost entirely. A church that washes its hands of power has often washed its hands of the people power crushes, and a faith with nothing to say to Pharaoh is not the faith of the Exodus. The warning is not against engagement. It is against the belief that engagement means seizing the throne. You can press hard against injustice and still refuse to believe Christ needs Caesar's sword to finish his work.

'If our side simply wins, righteousness advances and the country is saved. Voting the right way is the most important thing a faithful Christian can do.'

This is the temptation Bell names in himself, the wilderness offer in a voting booth, the belief that the kingdom is one majority away. Answer it gently with the cross. The kingdom of God arrived through political defeat, through the state's machinery turned against the Son of God and failing to keep him buried. A faith that needs to win has confessed it no longer believes its own gospel can accomplish anything. Caring about an election is not the sin. Putting your hope there is.

CLOSING PRAYER

Jesus, you stood in a high place and refused the kingdoms of the world, and you stood before Pilate and would not let your servants fight, and you took your throne by dying. We keep saying yes to the offer you refused and calling our yes obedience. Teach us the patience of a kingdom that does not need our majorities to arrive. Put our hope where it belongs, in the King who won by losing and cannot be voted out. Amen.

SESSION 5

How the Religious Right Was Built

AIM

To see that the political movement that taught a generation to read faithfulness as voting was assembled by named people in countable years, and can therefore be examined and repented.

TIMING

Open 5 min Discuss 35 min Close 10 min

KEY SCRIPTURE

Matthew 4:8-10. The same wilderness offer of the kingdoms for a single bow names the bargain the religious right was offered, real access for a redirected worship.

DISCUSSION

1. The young pastor thought the religious right was the weather, the climate faith had always lived in. Why does a movement want you to believe it is eternal rather than built?

Behind it: A thing that hides the date it was built does not want you to know it could have been built differently. The aim is to loosen the assumption that the current fusion of faith and party is simply what serious Christians have always been.

2. Bell grants real weight to the movement's defense, that the unborn are owed protection and a faith with no public voice surrenders something. How do we hold those true things while still examining the movement?

Behind it: Protect the even-handedness. The point is not to abandon convictions about justice or the unborn. It is to hold them as Christians rather than as soldiers. Make sure pro-life participants feel honored, not dismissed, before the harder history lands.

3. Balmer argues, in a contested reading, that the fire was lit over segregated schools, not abortion, and Bell is careful to call it contested. Why does Bell refuse to give you the clean story?

Behind it: The cleanest segregation-not-abortion story is too tidy for the evidence. Race and abortion were braided, not sequential. The honest finding is narrower and still uncomfortable. Model for the room how to hold a hard claim without overstating it, and do not let anyone weaponize it into a simple verdict.

4. In 1980 the coalition chose Reagan, a divorced actor not notably devout, over Carter, a born-again Sunday school teacher. What did that choice reveal about the movement?

Behind it: It was not about personal piety. It was about political power, and it would prefer the powerful sinner to the pious opponent. This is the bow in the wilderness made visible. Notice that the same preference can run in any direction when a tribe wants power more than righteousness.

5. Bell says the movement made him before he could examine it, that he voted his way into what he thought was discipleship for years. Where have you carried a construction and called it the ancient faith?

Behind it: The closing self-implication of the whole study. We were all handed a hundred-year-old construction and called it the gospel. Nobody lied on purpose. They handed us what they were handed. Invite gentle, non-defensive recognition, and go first.

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

What is one thing you were taught about faith and politics growing up that you have never actually stopped to examine?

ANTICIPATED OBJECTIONS

'This is just an attack on pro-life Christians, dragging up race to shame people who only ever wanted to protect the unborn.'

Bell explicitly refuses this. He grants the unborn are owed protection and says knowing this history does not require anyone to abandon their convictions about justice or the unborn. The call is to hold those convictions as Christians rather than as soldiers. The history is uncomfortable, but Bell states the segregation thesis as contested, not settled, and the honest point is only that race was woven in more deeply than the founding myth admits. That is not an attack on the pro-life cause. It is honesty about a genealogy.

'Fine, the religious right was built, so the answer is for Christians to just get out of politics entirely and stop imposing their faith on everyone.'

This is the opposite overcorrection, and Bell rules it out too. The error is not engagement. A faith with no public voice has surrendered something it had no right to surrender. The point is not withdrawal but refusing the bow that comes with the kingdoms, engaging as Christians who can still be corrected rather than as a tribe organized only to win. Examining the construction is not the same as abandoning the public square.

CLOSING PRAYER

Lord, we were handed a building and told it was a revelation, and most of us never learned the date it went up. Forgive us for the bows we made without feeling the descent, for the times we wanted the kingdoms more than the cross. Give us the freedom to examine what we were handed without fear, to keep what is true, to repent of what was tribe dressed as faith, and to follow you rather than a coalition. Amen.

REFERENCE

Three ways to run it

THE FULL STUDY (8 WEEKS)

Week 1: Orientation. Read the summary together, set ground rules, and walk session 1's opening questions slowly.

Week 2: Session 1, What It Is and What It Is Not, full discussion and practice.

Week 3: Session 2, Loving Versus Worshiping Your Country.

Week 4: Session 3, Flags in the Sanctuary.

Week 5: Session 4, Whose Kingdom, part one through the wilderness and Pilate.

Week 6: Session 4 continued, the cross and the election-night gauge, plus practice.

Week 7: Session 5, How the Religious Right Was Built.

Week 8: Integration. Revisit all five practices, the scripture index, and what each person is carrying out.

THE INTENSIVE (4 WEEKS)

Week 1: Sessions 1 and 2 together, definition and the love-versus-worship line.

Week 2: Session 3, Flags in the Sanctuary, with extended time on sacred space.

Week 3: Session 4, Whose Kingdom, the theological center of the study.

Week 4: Session 5, How the Religious Right Was Built, plus a short integration close.

AS WRITTEN (5 WEEKS)

Week 1: Session 1, What It Is and What It Is Not.

Week 2: Session 2, Loving Versus Worshiping Your Country.

Week 3: Session 3, Flags in the Sanctuary.

Week 4: Session 4, Whose Kingdom, Jesus and Political Power.

Week 5: Session 5, How the Religious Right Was Built.

REFERENCE

Bibliography

Taking America Back for God: Christian Nationalism in the United States, Andrew L. Whitehead and Samuel L. Perry. The careful sociological study that defines Christian nationalism as a cultural framework fusing civic and Christian identity, and measures it across a spectrum. The empirical spine of session 1.

The Irony of American History, Reinhold Niebuhr. Where Niebuhr names patriotism as a high devotion that becomes demonic when it claims the unconditioned loyalty belonging to God alone. Central to session 2.

Civil Religion in America, Robert N. Bellah. The 1967 essay that names civil religion as a real religion with sacred objects and holy days, the lens for the flags-in-the-sanctuary session.

America's God: From Jonathan Edwards to Abraham Lincoln, Mark A. Noll. Shows the colonists did not arrive with a unified Christian nation in mind and warns against reading providence directly off national events. Grounds the history in session 1.

Fundamentalism and American Culture, George M. Marsden. Traces how fundamentalism came to see itself as the last defender of a Christian civilization under siege, hardening after the 1925 Scopes trial.

Jesus and John Wayne: How White Evangelicals Corrupted a Faith and Fractured a Nation, Kristin Kobes Du Mez. Documents how a militant vision of Christian manhood fused with the defense of the nation across the twentieth century. Bell urges reading the footnotes even where readers distrust the conclusions.

The Gospel in a Pluralist Society, Lesslie Newbigin. Argues there is no neutral public square and that a gospel which only blesses a culture loses its power to call that culture to repentance. Used on both sides of session 1's even-handedness.

After Christendom, Stanley Hauerwas. Insists the first task of the church is to be the church, not to run the country. Handle with care as one voice among several, not the study's settled position.

Resident Aliens: Life in the Christian Colony, Stanley Hauerwas and William H. Willimon. Source of the claim that the church does not have a social strategy, the church is a social strategy. Anchors session 4. Use with care, as Bell affirms public engagement too.

The City of God, Augustine. The two cities built by two loves, mixed in this age so no earthly nation is the city of God. The deep background for sessions 1, 2, and 4.

The Scandal of the Evangelical Mind, Mark A. Noll. Source of the line that the scandal of the evangelical mind is that there is not much of one, naming the intellectual cost of trading theology for culture war. Anchors session 5.

God's Own Party: The Making of the Christian Right, Daniel K. Williams. Traces how Falwell's Moral Majority gathered Protestants, Catholics, and Mormons into a single voting bloc. The documented assembly history for session 5.

The Real Origins of the Religious Right, Randall Balmer. The Politico essay arguing segregation, not abortion, lit the movement's fire. Bell presents it as one influential and contested reading, not a settled verdict. Leader to confirm before stating it as fact, and present it as contested.